

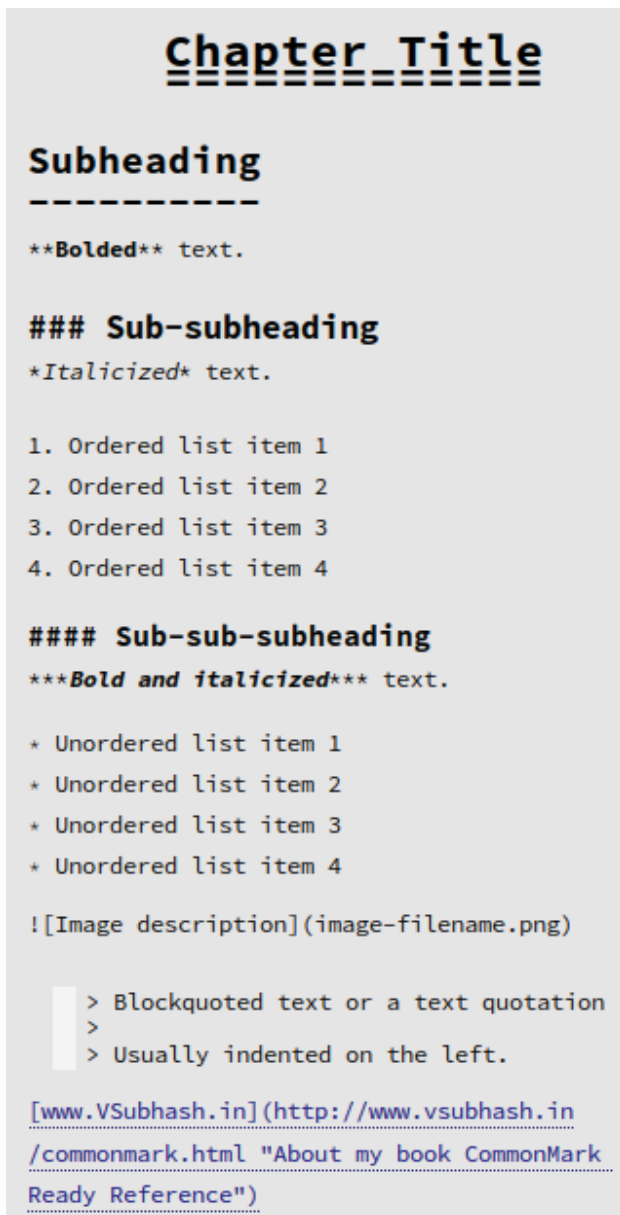


Figure 1: Markdown uses plain-text enhancements to mark up text

Figure 1 shows how Markdown uses plain text enhancements to mark-up text. A more comprehensive quick-reference card for CommonMark/Markdown is available for free from my website as a printable PDF.

CommonMark has a proper specification. It also has an implementation written in C that is blisteringly fast. I have compiled the source, and offer the Linux and Windows executables from my website. You can find the build instructions in the ebook.

After compilation or downloading the executable, you can convert your Markdown/CommonMark source documents like this:

```
commonmark --unsafe --validate-utf8 jokebook.md > jokebook.html
```

CommonMark can generate headings, paragraphs, blockquotes, images, links, lists, code spans and blocks, horizontal breaks and line breaks. That is about it. It cannot generate tables and other fancy stuff. If you want those, you can write raw HTML and use the *-unsafe* option. By default, CommonMark omits raw HTML to protect software systems from code injections.

The HTML that the CommonMark executable or the Markdown Perl script generates is validation-safe and well-structured. However, it will not have HTML, HEAD, TITLE or BODY tags. The executable's sole purpose is to create HTML markup that can be straightaway used in a pre-existing page or HTML template.

Imagine that this is the markdown source document:

```
Science Jokes
-----

* How many astronauts would it take to a screw a lightbulb?
  One to turn the bulb and several to prevent the spacecraft from spinning in the same direction.
* What did one radio wave say to another?
  "You are interfering with my work."
* What's a radio engineer's favourite food?
  A can of tuna....
```

CommonMark can be used to convert it like this:

```
echo '<!DOCTYPE html><html><title>2020 Jokebook</title></head><body>' > jokebook.html
commonmark --unsafe --validate-utf8 jokebook.md >> jokebook.html
echo '</body></html>' >> jokebook.html
```

The output HTML will look like this:

```
<!DOCTYPE html><html><title>2020 Jokebook</title></head><body>
<h2>Science Jokes</h2>
<ul>
<li><strong>How many astronauts would it take to a screw a lightbulb?</strong><br />
One to turn the bulb and several to prevent the spacecraft from spinning in the same direction.</li>
<li><strong>What did one radio wave say to another?</strong><br />
"You are interfering with my work."</li>
<li><strong>What's a radio engineer's favourite food?</strong><br />
```